hegemonic position the United States has enjoyed in the Pacific region since the end of World War II.

Auslin implies a certain skepticism about the viability of treating the "Indo-Pacific" as a single strategic theater—as in the Department of Defense's 2019 *Indo-Pacific Strategy Report*—and of making (in the report's words) "a free and open Indo-Pacific" the paramount goal of American policy. This, he suggests, is too vast a battlefield. Instead, Auslin revives the concept of an "Asiatic Mediterranean"—an idea he attributes to the Dutch-born cofounder of the Yale Institute of International Studies, Nicholas J. Spykman. In his book *The Geography of the Peace* (1944), Spykman developed Halford Mackinder's thesis that, if the Eurasian landmass was the "heartland" of geopolitics, then the "rimlands" at either end of it were the likely battlegrounds for its control. According to Spykman, the three key waterways were (in Auslin's formulation) "the North Sea and the Mediterranean in Europe, the Persian Gulf and littoral waters of the western Indian Ocean in the Middle East, and the East and South China Seas, along with the Yellow Sea, in Asia." A similar argument had been made by Mackinder himself in his 1943 essay "The Round World and the Winning of the Peace."

Auslin's focus is on the last of these: the Yellow Sea, the East China Sea, and the South China Sea. As the expanse of water between China and its neighbors—Korea, Japan, the Philippines, and Indonesia—this may well be regarded as Asia's answer to the Mediterranean, but China increasingly treats all three seas as its own coastal waters. "Today," Auslin argues, "America has lost a conscious understanding of the strategic importance of the inner seas and skies, at a moment when it faces the greatest challenge to its control of them since 1945. . . . China is contesting control not of the high seas . . . but of the marginal seas and skies of Asia, even while the United States remains dominant on the high seas of the Pacific."

In addition to its own naval and air forces, since the 1950s the United States has relied for its dominance of Asia's Mediterranean on five bilateral treaties: with Australia (1951), the Philippines (1951), South Korea